INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE 2023 SOUTH

For a place with such lush green feathers in its crown, it was only a matter of time before the India Today Conclave South came to Kerala. In 2016, it was already the first state in India to achieve 100 per cent literacy. Last month, Kerala also became the first state to be fully e-governed. Its neighbours are also not far behind when it comes to socio-economic progress. So, it was only fitting when India Today Group Editorial Director (Publishing), Raj Chengappa, in his opening remark at the conclave, lauded the region as the 'Incredible South' for standing out from the rest of the country on most major parameters. "I don't know why we use the term 'down south' to refer to this part of the country. It should really be up south," he said.

Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan echoed the sentiment in his keynote address. In keeping with its 2017 step that made access to the internet a basic right, the Left Democratic Front government recently launched the Kerala Fibre Optic Network (KFON) initiative to provide broadband connectivity to all houses and public offices. On the economy front, P. Rajeev, the minister for industries, law and coir, spoke about the MSME boom—in 2022-23, the 'Year of Enterprises', nearly 140,000 enterprises were set up, of which 45,000 are run by women entrepreneurs and 17 by transgenders. Additionally, Kerala's tourism sector also came into sharp focus at the conclave, with domestic arrivals touching 18.8 million in 2022 against the pre-pandemic high of 18.3 million in 2019. State tourism minister P.A. Mohammed Riyas attributed the success to the government's emphasis on areas

HEALTH: HANDLING POST-PANDEMIC THREATS



"The first Covid case was reported in 2020.... Our health system started preparing and using PPP kits, and soon we had a protocol, even before WHO had one"

VEENA GEORGE
Health and Family Welfare Minister, Kerala

"To think we're done with Covid and can wait for the next pandemic in the next century is a fallacy. The ground is fertile for a new virus to jump from an animal host to humans"

DR PRIYA ABRAHAM
Professor, Clinical Virology, CMC Vellore



SPOTLIGHT



"Large industries are not suitable for Kerala. But we have a big advantage, that is the availability of highly-skilled human resources"

P. RAJEEV
Industries, Law and Coir Minister, Kerala